

small amounts of dollars into local money several times a month. In many countries you'll have to go to an exchange dealer to get a free-market exchange rate. The free-market rate is also called the black-market or parallel rate. In many countries both the official and free-market rates are published in newspapers. To find a reputable exchange dealer, ask a hotel clerk or someone else who seems reliable in the host country.

HEALTH CARE

America's fee-for-service health care costs a bundle. The *Economist* has found that "the American taxpayer . . . is paying between four and six times as much for the health care of his poorest and sickest aged fellow-citizens as the British taxpayer does." In 1984, health care cost \$1,500 a head in the United States, an outrageous amount by international standards. In West Germany it cost \$900, in France \$800, in Japan \$500, and in healthy Singapore only \$200.

Whether Americans get value for all that money is another question. Newspapers tell of malpractice experiences that make us shudder: surgeons amputate the good arm or leg rather than the bad one; nurses mix up shots and kill people with injections. Europeans have a lower infant mortality rate and less infectious disease than Americans do. Life expectancy in low-cost Singapore is longer than in the United States.

Yet, some U.S. hospitals can provide state-of-the-art treatment for rare cancers or problem pregnancies. For brain surgery you go to New York, not Prague or Belgrade. For heart disease you go to Houston rather than Mexico City.

No wonder Americans are confused about health care abroad. It's confusing enough in the United States.

First, we need to define health and health care. When Americans talk about health care what we really mean is sickness care. Fee-for-service can do that to you. But health